



GOVERNANCE

ROLE OF CIVIL SERVICE

MODULE - 8

A CIVIL SERVICE DEBATE

GENERALISTS

- Tenure system of appointment requires generalists administrators.
- Generalists can act as effective liaisons between political heads, specialists and people.
- Generalists can adapt across several domains.
- Generalists have high caliber and ability to manage things.
- Generalists are required at all positions to carry on managerial functions.

SPECIALISTS

- Specialists have domain expertise which gives them a better edge in subject matter.
- Political leadership is better advised when assisted by specialists.
- Specialists can understand specific details in the field which helps them create realistic policies.
- Intelligent amateur theory advocated by generalists is obsolete.
- Problem solving is better managed by specialists owing to technical understanding.

GENERALIST VS SPECIALISTS DEBATE

- 1 The generalists and specialists are two important **formulation** of civil service in India.
- 2 The proper relationship between them is essential for **effective functioning** of the civil service.
- 3 But there has always **undying issues** between these two since the days of independence.



MINISTER-CIVIL SERVANT RELATIONSHIP

- 1 The **Second ARC Report** in its 10th Report states the following regarding the Minister-civil servant relationship. A **healthy working relationship between Ministers and civil servants is critical** for good governance.
- 2 While the principles governing the roles and responsibilities of Ministers and civil servants are well defined in political theory, in the **actual working** of this relationship this **division of responsibility becomes blurred** with both sides **often encroaching** upon the other's sphere of responsibility.
- 3 In any democracy, Ministers are responsible to the people through **Parliament** and therefore the **civil servants have to be accountable to the Minister.**



MINISTER-CIVIL SERVANT RELATIONSHIP

- 4 However, an impartial civil service is responsible not only to the government of the day but to the Constitution of the land to which they have taken an oath of loyalty.
- 5 At the same time, implementing the policies of the duly elected government is a core function of civil servants.
- 6 That is why the division of responsibility between the civil servants and ministers needs to be more clearly defined.
- 7 A framework in which responsibility and accountability is well defined would be useful.



MINISTER VS CIVIL SERVANT

Pfiffner has elaborated about the difference in activities of the Minister and the Civil servant, they are as follows

MINISTER

1. He is an **amateur**.
2. He is a **non-technical** persons.
3. He is partisan towards the **interest of his party**, the community to which he belongs and the region from when he hails from.

CIVIL SERVANT

1. He is a **professional** expert.
2. He is a **technical** and a subject matter and **administrative** expert.
3. He is **non-partisan** and carry out acts in a **neutral** manner as specified by the minister.

MINISTER VS CIVIL SERVANT

MINISTER

4. They are more involved in the formulation of the policy in order to implement the electoral promises made in their manifesto.
5. They are involved in more in the decision making process. They are the final authority to take decisions.
6. Their position is of temporary nature. Their memberships lasts only for a tenure of 5 years and has to be re-elected in order to gain membership again.

CIVIL SERVANT

4. They have no such obligation, their involvement is less compared to the ministers and they have other vital roles to play.
5. Their role is more advisory in nature. They render advice to the Ministers regarding various aspects.
6. They hold a permanent seat. They are recruited through merit and they rise in the organization via promotion. They only retire, when they attain their super annuation.

CIVIL SERVICE NEUTRALITY

- 1 Neutrality implies political impartiality or non-political nature of the civil service.
- 2 It means that the civil servants should remain politically neutral and be non-political and serve the government of the day impartially.
- 3 They should render free and frank advice to the executives without any consideration.



PROBLEMS OF BUREAUCRATISATION

Though the bureaucracy leads to efficiency, it also on the other hand leads to other problems. The following are some of the problems that arise because of the bureaucratisation:

1 In developing countries, since other **organs of governance**, such as the civil society, pressure groups etc. are **not well established**, hence the bureaucracy acts without any restraint with no one to control or question them.

2 The **politicians are amateurs** and often have to **heed the advice** of the much experienced and knowledgeable **civil servants**.

3 It is generally understood that the bureaucracy has to be under the control of the elected representatives. But in the developing countries the bureaucracy is **more powerful** and holds the **political office** below them.



PROBLEMS OF BUREAUCRATISATION

4 In some of the countries, the military and the civil servants remove the democratically elected government and assume power themselves and start ruling the country. Such dictatorship can be seen in some developing countries.

5 Lack of professionalism and poor capacity building.

6 Inefficient incentive systems that rewards the corrupt and the incompetent and not the upright and honest.

7 Outdated rules and procedures that limit the civil servant from performing effectively.



PROBLEMS OF BUREAUCRATISATION

- 8 Systemic discrepancies in promotion and empanelment.
- 9 Lack of proper transparency and accountability procedures - there is also no safety for whistle blowers.
- 10 Arbitrary and capricious transfers insecurity in tenures impedes institutionalization.
- 11 Political interference and administrative submission.
- 12 A gradual erosion in values and ethics.



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